the Buddha himself had walked, where the sacred texts were composed and preserved, and where learned masters provided daily exegeses on these texts'.[16] Eager to reform Chinese Buddhism, they often idealized Indian Buddhism in their accounts, especially Yijing. In other words, they wrote for an audience in a different cultural milieu and often pursued didactic goals, such as shaping behaviour and inspiring fellow monks at home. Much care is therefore required in interpreting their words.

And yet, their observations of social life are often quite sharp, realistic and astute. Many are wonderfully descriptive eyewitness accounts. Of course, modern historians must also rely on other sources and use their own judgement to decide what to believe and what not, as I myself have done. In another complication, however, most translations of these Chinese texts, on which nearly all Western scholarship is based, are more than a hundred years old. They date from an era when archaeological knowledge was scant, and much guesswork went into identifying sites with altered Chinese names in the originals. Further, every translation has some errors, idiosyncrasies and cultural blind spots. Is 'heretics' the right translation of Xuanzang's term for non-Buddhists, or does it betray the translator's baggage from an Abrahamic tradition? Is 'nation' the right term for the subcontinent in the seventh century? Translations by a new generation of scholars are therefore long overdue, which, one hopes, will also provide fresh new insights into these travellers' worlds.

Naming Their Destination

Both Xuanzang and Yijing call the subcontinent 'the West', made up of five parts or 'five Indies', comprising many countries (or kingdoms). Yijing reports visiting over thirty countries in 'the West' and Xuanzang thinks it is 'divided into seventy countries or so'. 'Each country has diverse customs,' writes Xuanzang. Nevertheless, it's clear that all three Chinese visitors, as outsiders, saw an ethnocultural distinctiveness about the subcontinent (likely excluding the North East, where none of them seem to have travelled); it's not clear what, if any, common identity its residents themselves consciously shared with each other. There was the notion of *Aryavarta* but it was an elite identity that didn't extend much beyond urban